



Rating:
9/10
Publisher:
THQ
Developer:
GSC
System Requirements:
Pentium IV 3 GHz,
1 GB RAM,
256 MB Direct X 9.0c
ready graphics card,
6-GB hard drive space

ere

across hostile mutants of various kinds, heavily-armed stalkers who'll be either neutral or hostile, and various deadly things—not to mention equally lethal, highly radioactive zones.

This is where S.T.A.L.K.E.R. really comes into its own. A first person shooter / RPG, this game is the first of its kind. Its not about upgrading character stats, but improving your own gameplay skills. The storyline revolves around the main missions, although there's a goodly dose of side missions in S.T.A.L.K.E.R. enough for some 40+ hours of gameplay. What's unique is the sheer freedom the game allows you in pursuing the missions. There's never a feeling of being forced into a particular mission, nor any limitations on how you achieve your objectives.

It's the sheer eerie beauty of the zone that will grab you though. Gnarled trees, rumbling thunderstorms with intermittent lightning bolts, junkyards of dead vehicles, and abandoned buildings in various states of disrepair are all part of the eerie atmosphere you'll experience. You have no friends except your gear, and death is only an empty magazine away.

With the right kind of hardware, S.T.A.L.K.E.R. looks absolutely stunning. It has one of the most immersive soundtracks I've ever experienced. The growls from mutants, rustles in bushes, the constant moaning of the wind, among other indefinable ambient sounds through the trees will leave you constantly on edge, just as the developers intended.

Skirmishes with mutants and rival stalkers are common, and you'll need to watch yourself: The AI is extremely nasty, with enemies using cover as intelligently as you, ditto the tactics. Some of the mutants lack AI for the most part, but they more than compensate with raw speed and agility.

While I won't spoil any more of the plot, I can tell you the game has seven different endings—open-endedness unlimited!

Will absolutely realistic weaponry and damage models, S.T.A.L.K.E.R. is as close to the real thing as you can get. Need a verdict? Play it! Right after a system upgrade, of course...

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